

German idealism



From the late 18th century, German culture – music, literature, art and philosophy – dominated the Western world for more than 100 years.

While French and British philosophers dominated the Enlightenment period, from the 1780s philosophy began to flourish more in the German-speaking world. Immanuel Kant was the first of the great German philosophers, introducing ideas that became the starting point for a century of German philosophy. Bringing together the apparently opposing views of rationalism and empiricism, Kant proposed a metaphysics he called ‘transcendental idealism’, which explained the world as we experience it

through our senses at the same time as admitting the existence of a world we cannot apprehend, the world as it is in itself. His ideas inspired followers included Schelling, Fichte, Schopenhauer and Hegel, each with his own interpretation of idealism. Idealism also provoked a reaction, as philosophers such as Feuerbach and Marx adapted some of Hegel's ideas to argue for a materialist view. This was also critical of religion and marked the beginnings of an increasingly sceptical, atheist philosophy culminating in Nietzsche's famous declaration that 'God is dead'.